



MyGurukul

SACRED WISDOM — SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2026



SACRED TEXT

yathoktena vidhānena viprān sprṣtvānumoditaḥ | 20.038a
sopavāsaś ca khādeta devabrāhmaṇasannidhau | | 38 | | 20.038c
viṣaṃ vegaklamāpetam sukhena yadi jīryate | 20.039a
viśuddham iti tam jñātvā rājā satkr̥tya mokṣayet | | 39 | | 20.039c
tvaṃ viṣa brahmaṇaḥ putraḥ satyadharmaratau sthitaḥ | 20.040a
śodhayainaṃ naraṃ pāpāt satyenāsyāmṛtibhava | | 40 | | 20.040c

— Nāradaśmṛti, Chapter 4, Verse 1

GURU'S INTERPRETATION

This passage from the Nāradaśmṛiti delves into a fascinating and somewhat perplexing ritual involving poison, truth, and purification. In essence, it describes an ordeal by poison, a method used to determine the guilt or innocence of an accused individual. The accused, after touching learned Brahmins and receiving their blessings, would fast and then consume poison in the presence of deities and Brahmins. The key was whether the poison was digested without causing debilitating effects. If the person survived the ordeal seemingly unharmed, it was taken as a sign of their innocence, and the king would honor them and set them free.

The logic behind this practice rests on the belief that truth possesses a purifying power. Verse 40 specifically invokes the poison as a "son of Brahma," an entity devoted to truth and dharma. The invocation implores the poison to cleanse the accused of sin and to become like nectar through the power of truth. It suggests that a person grounded in truth and righteousness would be protected from the poison's harmful effects. This is not merely about physical resilience; it is about spiritual alignment.

While the literal practice of consuming poison to prove innocence seems archaic and dangerous from our modern perspective, we can extract a deeper spiritual meaning. The "poison" can be seen as the negativity, challenges, and difficult situations we face in our lives. The ability to "digest" this poison, to overcome these challenges without being corrupted or destroyed by them, signifies our spiritual strength and the purity of our intentions. When you face adversity with truthfulness, integrity, and a commitment to dharma, you are more likely to emerge stronger and more purified. Your commitment to inner truth acts as a shield, mitigating the harmful effects of external negativity. This passage encourages you to cultivate inner resilience and to face life's trials with unwavering honesty.

REFLECTION FOR TODAY

In what ways can you transform the "poisons" in your life – the challenges and negative experiences – into opportunities for spiritual growth and purification?